Louis Pasteur



Born in Dole, France, in 1822, Pasteur was the son of a poor tanner. He was an average student, but he worked hard, obtaining his degree in 1842 and his doctorate in science in 1847. After teaching in various universities, in 1867 he became Professor of Chemistry at the Sorbonne in Paris. His major research interest was the fermentation process. Pasteur discovered that the fermentation of wine and beer was caused by germs—microbes. He also discovered that microbes could be killed by short, mild heat treatment—a process now named after him as “pasteurization.” Pasteur’s “germ theory” led to the wider development of vaccines, which remain a vital method of disease control. In 1887, he established the Pasteur Institute, which opened in 1888 and continues to help prevent and fight diseases.

Key works

1870 *Studies on Silk Worm Disease*

1878 *Microbes: Their Role in Fermentation, Putrefaction, and the Contagion*

1886 *Treatment of Rabies*

See also: Classification of living things • The microbiological environment • The ecosystem • One Health